

the
WEEKEND
THAT WENT
ASTRAY

MY GIRLFRIEND
TOOK ME AND
A FRIEND
CAMPING.

J. J. VALE

THE WEEKEND THAT WENT ASTRAY

My Girlfriend Took Me and a Friend
Camping

JJ Vale

PMI

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Trevor's SUV smelled like energy drinks. The bass from the speakers vibrated through my seat, some band I didn't recognize. My girlfriend Melissa had her bare feet up on the dashboard, toenails painted dark purple, and she was eating Red Vines from a plastic tub in her lap.

"Want one?" she asked, waving the candy at Trevor with a snicker.

"I'm good."

She twisted around to look at me. "You Dave?"

"No thanks."

She shrugged and went back to chewing, watching the landscape change outside her window. We'd been on the road for ninety minutes. The city had given way to outlet malls, then farmland, and now we were in the foothills, climbing gradually into pine country.

"So this place has showers, right?" Melissa asked.

Trevor laughed. "It's a campground, not a resort. But there's a bathroom building. Toilets, sinks. Pretty good showers, but the river is better, the lake too."

"Gross."

"You can swim in the river."

"It's not the same thing."

"It's three days. You'll survive."

Melissa made a face but didn't argue. She pulled another Red Vine from the tub.

I looked out the window, half-listening to them talk. This whole trip had come together fast. Trevor mentioned it at the bakery last week, talking to one of the other delivery guys about his plans, a long weekend camping trip, same spot he went to every summer.

Melissa overheard and asked him about it, when he was loading empty pallets back into his truck. I wasn't there, but she told me about it.

"That Trevor guy from work is going camping this weekend," she said, flipping through Netflix without settling on anything.

"Oh yeah?"

"He said we could come if we wanted."

I'd looked hard at her. "He invited us camping"?

"Not exactly invited us. I asked if other people ever came up with him, and he said sure, and then I asked if we could come, and he said sure."

"You actually want to go camping?"

"Why not? We never do anything like that. We just sit around and watch TV. Could be something different."

"I don't know how to camp."

"Neither do I." She laughed. "We can have a nature adventure."

She'd looked at me with that expression she got when she really wanted something. Not quite pleading, but close. So I said yes, we could try.

Now we were out here, barreling up a two-lane highway in Trevor's SUV, getting farther from the city with every mile.

"Exit's coming up," Trevor said, slowing down.

We turned off onto a smaller road, then another, each one narrower than the last. The pavement turned to gravel. Trees pressed in close on both sides, blocking out most of the sky.

"How much farther?" Melissa asked looking up like the world was closing in on her.

"Twenty minutes."

She nodded and went back to her candy. The tub was half-empty.

Trevor turned up the music. Melissa bobbed her head to the beat. I watched the back of her ponytail swing side to side.

The road got rougher. The SUV bounced over ruts and potholes. Melissa's feet came off the dashboard and she braced herself with one hand on the door handle.

"Jesus, Trevor. Are you trying to kill us?"

"Relax. The SUV can handle it."

"My spine can't."

"Your spine is fine."

She shot him a look but didn't say anything.

The trees were massive here, their trunks thick and covered in moss. Shafts of sunlight cut through the canopy, illuminating dust motes in the air. It was cooler too, the temperature dropping as we climbed.

I'd never been this far out of the city and never really wanted to be either. But Melissa had been restless, talking about how boring everything

was, how she felt stuck. Maybe this weekend would be good for us. Or maybe it would just be three uncomfortable days sleeping on the ground.

Either way, it was too late to back out now.

Trevor took a sharp turn and the SUV tilted. Melissa grabbed the handle above her door.

"Seriously!"

"We're almost there."

The road leveled out and widened. Through the trees, I could see a shimmer of water. The river he mentioned, probably.

Trevor slowed down, looking for something. Then he turned onto an even smaller road, barely more than a dirt path, and followed it for another minute before pulling into a clearing.

And, here we are," he said, killing the engine.

Melissa opened her door and stepped out, stretching. I climbed out of the back, my legs stiff.

The clearing was surrounded by trees. A fire ring sat in the middle, filled with old ash and charred wood. Beyond it, maybe fifty feet away, was the river.

"This is it?" Melissa asked.

"This is it."

She looked around, hands on her hips. "Okay. It's not terrible."

Trevor was already at the back of the SUV, pulling out gear. "Come on. Let's get the tent up before it gets dark," he said. "Everything else can wait."

Melissa stood by the passenger door, turning in a slow circle. Her face changed. The careful reservation she carried in the city was gone. She looked at the trees, the river, the clearing like she was trying to memorize them.

"This is beautiful," she said. Trevor hauled out a massive bag.

"Yeah, it's pretty great. Remote enough to feel like wilderness, close enough to the car that we're not roughing it too bad."

He dropped the bag near the fire ring, a circle of blackened stones someone had left from a previous trip. Melissa walked over, standing close to him as he unzipped the bag.

"What can I do?" she asked.

"Just hang tight for a second. Let me figure out the best spot for the tent."

Trevor walked the perimeter of the clearing, eyes on the ground. Melissa followed a few steps behind, watching him work. I grabbed a cooler from the SUV and carried it to the picnic table.

"Here," Trevor said, toeing a flat spot about twenty feet from the fire ring.

"Ground's level, good drainage, close enough to everything but not too close to the fire."

The tent spilled out of the bag, a mass of beige fabric. Trevor started separating pieces. Poles in one pile, stakes in another.

"Dave, grab that end," he said, pointing to a corner of the tent body. I took hold of the fabric. It was thick, coarse under my fingers. Trevor moved to the opposite corner and we spread it out. The thing was enormous, easily twelve feet across.

"Melissa, can you lay out those poles?" Trevor asked. She knelt and started organizing them, her ponytail falling over her shoulder as she worked, and she glanced up at Trevor, watching him move around the tent, checking corners, adjusting the lay of it.

"You're really good at this," she said.

"Practice."

Trevor came over to where I stood dumbfounded.

"Let's get the poles through. There are sleeves sewn into the tent. See them?"

I looked where he pointed and saw the fabric channels. He threaded the first pole through with quick, practiced movements. When he reached the end, he fitted it into a grommet at the corner.

"Got it?" he asked.

"Yep."

"Grab the other side and lift when I say."

I moved to the opposite corner. We lifted on three. The pole bowed, the tent rising. Trevor secured his end and moved to help me. My fingers fumbled with the grommet, the pole tip slipping past it.

"Here," Melissa said, coming up beside me. She reached for the pole, her hand brushing mine, but she was looking at Trevor.

"Show me how?"

Trevor came over, positioning himself behind her. His hands guided hers, helping her fit the pole into the grommet. She leaned back slightly as he worked, her shoulder against his chest.

"There you go," he said.

"Thanks," she said, turning her head to smile at him. We repeated the process with three more poles. I felt slow. Melissa helped, but mostly she watched Trevor work, asking questions about the tent, about camping, about how he knew where everything went.

When the tent stood, it towered over us, easily seven feet tall at the peak, the canvas walls taut and solid. Trevor walked the perimeter, hammering stakes. Melissa followed, handing him stakes before he asked, learning the rhythm.

"You're a natural," Trevor said. She laughed.

"I'm follow your lead and I aim to please."

When a stake flew from Trevor's hand and landed near Melissa's feet, she bent to pick it up, and as she straightened she handed it to him, her fingers lingering on his for a moment. She glanced at me, checking if I noticed. I did. Trevor finished the last stake and stepped back.

"There. Home for the next few days."

Melissa stepped inside through the front flap.

"This is huge," her voice came from within. I followed her in. The interior stretched wide and dim, the canvas filtering the sunlight to a warm amber. There was room for three sleeping pads with space left over.

"Where do you want the bags?" I asked. Trevor appeared in the doorway, arms full of sleeping bags.

"Doesn't matter. We can sort it out tonight."

He tossed them onto the pads. Melissa knelt and unzipped one, running her hand over the flannel lining.

"These are so soft."

"My dad always said if you're going to camp, at least sleep warm."

"Your dad sounds smart."

"He was."

Melissa looked up at him, her expression softening.

"Was?"

"He died a few years ago."

"I'm sorry."

Trevor shrugged.

"It's okay. But yeah, he taught me most of this stuff."

We hauled in the rest of the gear. Melissa worked alongside Trevor, their movements synchronized. When they both reached for the same duffel,

their hands touched. She pulled back with a laugh.

"Sorry," she said.

"No worries."

But she was looking at him with something in her eyes I hadn't seen before. Trevor strung a rope between two trees for the food bags, as he worked, reaching up to tie the rope, his shirt rode up, exposing a strip of his stomach. Melissa watched, then caught herself and looked at me. Her cheeks were flushed.

The sun dropped lower, the light going golden. Trevor built the fire with the same competence he had shown with everything else. Melissa sat on a log nearby, watching his hands stack the wood, watching the way he moved.

"How do you know to build it like that?" she asked.

"Structure matters. You want air flow, but you also want the heat concentrated."

He struck a match and touched it to birch bark. The flame caught and spread. Melissa's face was lit by the growing fire, her eyes bright. We unfolded camping chairs and arranged them around the fire ring. Trevor pulled three beers from the cooler, twisted the caps off, handed them around. The bottles were still cold. I sat and watched Melissa watch Trevor. The way she leaned forward when he talked. The way she laughed at things he said. The way she kept glancing at me, checking my reaction.

Trevor leaned back in his chair. "So what made you guys want to try camping?"

"Melissa's idea," I said. She smiled.

"I've been reading about it. But reading's not the same as doing. That's why I wanted to come with someone who actually knows what they're doing."

"Happy to help you out."

"Where did you learn all this?" she asked. "You make it look so easy."

Trevor took a pull from his beer.

"Dad used to take me and my brother out every summer."

Melissa leaned forward, elbows on her knees, her eyes locked on him.

"Tell me about it."

The firelight danced across her face. Her whole attention was focused on Trevor, drinking in his words. She kept glancing at me, a question in her eyes. I took a drink from my beer.

"He'd make us figure things out ourselves," Trevor said, his eyes on the fire. "Like, he'd show us how to do something once, then step back and watch us struggle through it. Setting up the tent, starting a fire, filtering water. He said if we couldn't do it without him watching, we had no business being out here."

"That sounds tough," Melissa said.

"It was. But it worked. By the time I was twelve, I could set up camp in the dark if I had to."

Melissa leaned forward, her face intent. "What's the hardest thing you had to learn?"

Trevor thought for a moment. "Navigation, probably. Reading a map is one thing. But being in the middle of nowhere with just a compass and your sense of direction? That's a different cat to skin."

"Have you ever gotten lost?" she asked.

"Once. I was fourteen. Went off trail to check out this waterfall my brother and I had seen from a distance. Took me three hours to find my way back."

"Were you scared?"

"Terrified. But that's when the lessons stick."

The fire popped, sending sparks into the darkening sky. I took a drink from my beer, watching them talk.

"You can't learn that from a book," Melissa said.

"No. Books give you theory. Experience gives you the real thing."

She nodded, her eyes bright. "That's what I've been realizing. I've read all this stuff about wilderness survival, about camping, about being outdoors. But sitting here right now, watching you work, it's completely different."

Trevor smiled. "You're a quick study though. You picked up the tent setup fast."

"Only because you showed me."

Their eyes held for a moment longer. Then Melissa looked at me. A sound came from the woods, low and rhythmic. Melissa turned toward it.

"What is that?"

Trevor stood, tilting his head to listen.

"Barred owl. Hear the pattern?"

We all listened. The call came again, clearer this time.

"They say it sounds like 'who cooks for you, who cooks for you all,'" Trevor said. Melissa stood, moving closer to him.

"I can hear it now."

Trevor walked to the edge of the clearing. Melissa followed. I stayed in my chair, watching them. Trevor crouched near a patch of bare dirt. Melissa knelt beside him.

"See these?" he said, pointing.

"What are they?"

"Deer tracks. See the shape? Two toes, kind of heart-shaped."

She leaned in closer, her shoulder against his.

"How fresh are they?"

"Hard to say. Maybe this morning. Ground holds tracks pretty well when it's soft like this."

Her hand moved to steady herself, landing on his forearm. She left it there while she studied the tracks.

"That's amazing," she said.

"I would have just walked right past them."

"Most people do. You have to know what to look for."

They stood and walked back to the fire. Melissa's hand brushed Trevor's arm as they sat down, a touch that looked accidental but lingered a fraction too long.

"So it's all about observation," she said.

"Paying attention."

"Exactly. You watch, you listen, you notice patterns."

"Is that how you learn people too?" she asked.

Trevor looked at her. "What do you mean?"

"I mean, you seem like you read people well. You notice things."

He shrugged. "I guess. Same principle applies. You pay attention to what someone does, not just what they say."

Melissa's eyes flicked to me, then back to Trevor. "And what have you noticed about us?"

Trevor leaned back, considering. "You're curious. Both of you. You ask good questions. You're willing to try new things even when you're out of your element."

"What else?"

"You're different from each other. Dave's more internal, processes things quietly. You're more external, you need to talk through things to understand

them."

Melissa smiled. "That's true."

"But you balance each other," Trevor added, glancing at me. "That's good."

The fire burned down to coals now, glowing orange in the darkness. The temperature dropped. Melissa wrapped her arms around herself.

"Cold?" Trevor asked.

"A little."

He stood and added another log to the fire, then pulled his flannel shirt off, leaving just his t-shirt. He handed the flannel to Melissa.

"Here."

She took it, their fingers touching.

"Thanks."

She put it on, pulling it around herself. It was too big, the sleeves hanging past her hands. She looked at me again.

"We should probably turn in," Trevor said. "If we want to explore tomorrow, we should get some rest."

We stood and walked to the tent. Trevor unzipped the flap and clicked on the battery lantern inside. The sleeping bags were laid out side by side, Dave, Melissa, Trevor.

I pulled off my shoes and set them by the door. Melissa did the same, then crawled into her bag, still wearing Trevor's flannel.

Trevor stripped off his t-shirt, down to just his boxers, and climbed into his bag. I hesitated, then pulled off my shirt and pants, leaving my underwear on, and slid into my bag. Trevor reached over and clicked off the lantern. Darkness swallowed everything.

"Night," he said.

"Goodnight," Melissa murmured. I listened to them breathing. Melissa shifted, the bag crinkling. The flannel rustled as she moved. I could smell it from here, smell Trevor's scent mixed with woodsmoke. Trevor's breathing slowed, deepened, evening out into the rhythm of sleep.

Melissa's breathing changed too, becoming slower, heavier. I stared into the dark.

Outside, the river made its constant sound. The owl called again, farther away now.

I thought about the way Melissa had touched Trevor's arm. The way she looked at him by the fire. The way she kept glancing at me, checking if I

noticed. I noticed everything.

Beside me, Melissa shifted again. Her hand moved in the darkness, finding mine between our sleeping bags. She squeezed once, then let go.

In the morning, light filtered through the canvas, turning everything amber. I woke to the sound of the zipper, the tent flap opening, boots on dirt. Trevor was already up, moving outside with quiet efficiency.

Melissa stirred beside me, her eyes still closed. Trevor's flannel had slipped off one shoulder during the night. Her ponytail had come loose, strands of hair falling across her face. She made a small sound and pulled the sleeping bag tighter.

I sat up, my back stiff, and found my shoes.

Outside, Trevor crouched by the fire ring, arranging kindling. He had the camp stove set up on the picnic table, a kettle already balanced on the burner.

"Morning," he said without looking up.

"Morning."

"Coffee's almost ready. Mugs are in that bin."

I found three enamel mugs and set them on the table. The kettle began to hiss. Trevor stood and walked to the river, splashing water on his face. When he came back, his hair was wet, slicked back, water dripping down his neck. ‘

Melissa emerged from the tent, wrapped in Trevor's flannel over her clothes from yesterday. She looked around the clearing, blinking in the morning light.

"Sleep okay?" Trevor asked.

"Better than I expected," she said. "Your shirt kept me warm."

"Keep it as long as you want."

She smiled, pulling it tighter around herself.

The kettle whistled. Trevor poured water over instant coffee in each mug. We stood around the table, drinking, not saying much.

The morning was cool, the sun just clearing the trees. Trevor pulled out bagels and cream cheese. We ate standing up, tearing the bagels in half, passing the tub around.

"There's a lookout point about a mile from here," Trevor said.

"Incredible view of the valley. You two want to check it out?"

"Absolutely," Melissa said, her face lighting up. I nodded.

"Sure."

We cleaned up and started walking. The trail began at the edge of the clearing, a narrow path through the trees marked by faded blazes on the trunks. Trevor led, Melissa followed close behind him. I trailed a few feet back. The forest was dense here. Pine and fir crowding close, the ground covered in needles and moss. Trevor pointed at things as we walked, a shelf fungus on a rotting log, a woodpecker hole carved into a trunk. Each time he stopped, Melissa moved closer to hear what he was saying.

"See that?" Trevor said, crouching near a plant with broad leaves. Melissa knelt beside him.

"What is it?"

"Trillium. They only bloom for a couple weeks in spring. We just missed them."

"It's beautiful anyway."

The trail climbed, the ground turning rocky, at one point, the path narrowed where it crossed a steep section. Large stones jutted out, slick with moss. Trevor climbed up first, then turned back.

"Careful here. It's slippery."

He reached down. Melissa took his hand. He pulled her up. His other hand went to the small of her back, steadying her as she found her footing. But when she was stable, his hand stayed there.

"Thanks," she said, looking up at him.

"No problem."

They started walking again. I noticed their hands were still joined. Trevor leading, Melissa following, their fingers interlaced. I climbed up on my own, using a different route. The trail leveled out. They walked ahead of me, still holding hands. Melissa leaned close to Trevor as he pointed out a bird perched high in a pine.

"Cooper's hawk," he said.

"See the banded tail?"

She followed his gaze, her shoulder pressing against his arm. They didn't let go of each other's hands. We reached the lookout point. The valley spread below us, endless green broken by the silver thread of a river. Mountains rose in the distance, their peaks still touched with snow. Melissa stood at the edge, Trevor beside her, their hands still joined.

"This is incredible."

"Best view in the area," Trevor said. She turned to him.

"Thank you for bringing us here."

"I'm glad you came."

They stood close, looking at each other. I stood a few feet back, watching. The hike back was quieter. They walked hand in hand the whole way, Trevor pointing out things, Melissa asking questions, their voices low and intimate. When we reached camp, the sun was high, the clearing bright and warm.

"River?" Trevor suggested. We changed in the tent. Me in board shorts, Melissa in her one-piece with shorts over it. When she emerged, Trevor was already in his swim trunks, bare-chested, the compass tattoo on his ribs visible in the sunlight. We walked to the river beach. The water was clear, moving fast over smooth stones. Trevor waded in to his knees, testing the temperature.

"It's cold," he called back, grinning. Then he dove forward, disappearing under the surface. Melissa stood at the edge, arms wrapped around herself. She watched where Trevor had gone under. He surfaced a few feet out, water streaming from his hair, droplets catching the light. He shook his head, sending spray in all directions.

"Come on," he said.

"It's not that bad."

Melissa dipped one foot in and pulled it back.

"Liar."

"Just go fast. Don't think about it."

She took a step in. The water rose to her ankles. She winced but kept moving. Trevor swam closer, his strokes smooth and easy. He surfaced a few feet from her, water streaming down his face, his shoulders.

"You got this," he said, reaching out his hand. She looked at his hand, then at me standing on the shore, then back at Trevor. She took another step, the water at her knees now. Trevor waited, his hand extended, water dripping from his fingers. Melissa took Trevor's hand and he pulled her deeper. The water rose to her thighs. She gasped at the cold but kept moving. She looked back at the shore, at me, then down at herself. Her arms crossed over her chest.

"I feel so exposed," she said, laughing nervously. Trevor glanced at her, then at the river, the trees, the sky.

"Out here, it's all just natural. Sun, water, skin. Nobody's judging."

He let go of her hand and floated on his back, eyes closed.

"Feel that sun? That's what you want. Cold water, hot sun."

Melissa's arms slowly dropped to her sides. She looked down at the water, at her body visible beneath the surface, then at Trevor floating nearby. She took another step, the water at her waist now.

"That's it," Trevor said, rolling upright.

"Once you're in, it's fine."

She pushed off and swam a few strokes, her movements tentative. Trevor swam beside her, keeping pace. I stayed in the shallows, the water at my knees. The current was gentle, the stones smooth under my feet. They swam together, Trevor showing her a deeper pool on the far side where the water was calmer. She followed him, gaining confidence with each stroke, at one point, Trevor splashed her. She shrieked, splashing back. They laughed, the sound carrying across the water. I waded back to the beach and sat on the stones, after a while, they swam back. Melissa's strokes were stronger now, more assured. They walked out of the water together, dripping, and collapsed onto the beach a few feet from me.

"That was amazing," Melissa said, wringing out her ponytail.

"Told you. Cold water, hot sun."

They lay there, drying. The heat soaked into the stones beneath us. Melissa stretched out on her back, arms at her sides, eyes closed. Trevor sat with his knees up, looking at the river.

"This spot never gets old," he said.

"Different every time I come here."

"Do you come alone usually?" Melissa asked, eyes still closed.

"Sometimes. Sometimes with friends. It's good for clearing your head either way."

She turned her head to look at him.

"What do you need to clear your head from?"

"Just life. Work. The usual stuff."

"Do you like your job?"

"It's fine. Pays the bills. Lets me do this on weekends."

She smiled.

"That's a good trade."

We stayed until the sun started to drop. Then we walked back to camp, our swimsuits damp, skin warm, at the campsite, Trevor pulled out the cooler and started laying out food. Vegetables, chicken, rice. Melissa moved beside him at the picnic table, chopping peppers while he prepared the chicken. I grabbed plates from the bin, set them out, but there was not much

else for me to do. They had found a rhythm together, passing things back and forth without asking, moving around each other like they had done this before.

"Can you get the stove going?" Trevor asked me.

"Sure."

I worked on the camp stove while they continued prepping. I could hear them talking, their voices low, punctuated by Melissa's laugh. When everything was ready, we cooked together, though mostly I watched while Trevor and Melissa handled the actual cooking. They stood close, her shoulder brushing his arm, his hand steadying the pan while she stirred. We ate as the sun set, the clearing going golden. Trevor built up the fire. We moved to the camping chairs, beers in hand. The sky darkened. Stars began to appear. Melissa pulled her knees up to her chest, the flannel wrapped around her.

"Can I ask you guys something?"

"Sure," Trevor said.

"How do you know when there's chemistry between people? Like, real attraction?"

I shifted in my chair. Trevor looked at her, waiting.

"I've been thinking about it," she continued.

"Why we're drawn to certain people. What that pull is."

"Biology, mostly," Trevor said.

"Pheromones, physical attraction. Your body knows before your brain does."

"But how do you know it's real? That it's mutual?"

"You feel it. It's like a current between you."

Melissa nodded, her eyes on the fire.

"Yeah. That makes sense."

She was quiet for a moment, then looked at me.

"What do you think, Dave?"

"I don't know. I guess I've never thought about it that much."

"Really? You've never felt that pull toward someone?"

"I mean, toward you. When we first met."

She smiled.

"That's sweet. But what about just in general? That moment when you realize there's something between you and another person?"

I took a drink from my beer.

"I guess."

Trevor leaned back.

"It's pretty obvious when it's there. The way people look at each other, the way they find excuses to touch, the way conversation flows."

"Exactly," Melissa said. She looked at him, then at me.

"Sometimes you can just feel it, right? That pull?"

"Yeah," Trevor said. The fire cracked. Melissa stared into the flames.

"What if we tested it?" she said.

"Tested what?" I asked. She looked at me, then at Trevor.

"The chemistry. The pull. What if we could see it happening? Observe it in real time?"

Trevor's expression became cautious.

"What do you mean?"

Melissa turned to face both of us.

"I mean, what if we did something to see how we all react? To see what that pull feels like when it's happening?"

Silence. The fire cracked again, a log shifting, sending up sparks. I stared at her, my heart starting to pound.

"Just to see what happens," she said softly. Melissa leaned forward, her eyes bright in the firelight.

"I'm not talking about anything crazy. Just a kiss. Between me and Trevor. To see how it feels, for all of us."

My throat went tight. I couldn't find words.

"It's just curiosity," she continued.

"We're all adults. We're all here together, and I think there's something interesting happening. Don't you feel it?"

Trevor looked at me, his expression uncertain.

"I don't know if this is...,"

"I'm just asking," Melissa said, turning to me. "Dave, would you be okay with it? Me kissing Trevor?"

My mouth was dry. I swallowed, trying to find my voice. The question hung in the air, impossible and real.

"I don't know," I said.

"That's not a no," Melissa said softly.

"It's not a yes either."

"But would you want to see what happens? To see how we all react?"

I looked at the fire, at Trevor, at Melissa. Her face was open, curious, excited in a way I had rarely seen. The pause stretched out. My heart pounded.

"Okay," I whispered. Melissa's face lit up.

"Yeah?"

I nodded, not trusting my voice. She turned to Trevor.

"And you?"

Trevor ran his hand through his hair.

"Are you sure about this? Both of you?"

"I am," Melissa said.

"Dave?"

"I said okay."

Trevor looked at me for a long moment, searching my face.

"If you're both really sure."

"We are," Melissa said. She stood. The movement was slow. She walked around the fire, her steps careful on the uneven ground, and stopped in front of Trevor's chair. He looked up at her, his face uncertain. She leaned down, her hands going to the arms of his chair, bracketing him in. Then her right hand moved to cup his face, her thumb resting on his cheekbone.

"Okay?" she whispered. He nodded. She leaned in and kissed him. Soft at first. Her lips pressing against his, tentative, testing. Trevor sat still, hands on the chair arms, letting her lead. Then his hand came up, resting on her waist, and the kiss deepened. I watched from across the fire. Every detail. The way her fingers threaded into his hair at the temple. The way his grip tightened on her waist. The angle of their heads, tilting to fit together better. The small sound she made, caught in her throat, somewhere between a gasp and a sigh. It lasted longer than I expected. Long enough for my chest to tighten, for my breathing to become shallow, for heat to flood my body in a way I didn't understand. When they pulled apart, Melissa's eyes stayed closed for a beat. Her hand was still on Trevor's face. His hand was still on her waist. Then she opened her eyes and looked at him. She smiled. She straightened and walked back around the fire to her chair. She sat down, pulling her knees up, the flannel wrapped around her. The fire crackled.

"We should get some sleep," he said. We walked to the tent without speaking. Trevor unzipped the flap and clicked on the lantern. We crawled in and pulled off our shoes. I climbed into my sleeping bag on the left.

Melissa got into hers in the middle. Trevor on the right. Trevor reached over and clicked off the lantern.

I lay on my back, staring at nothing, my heart still pounding. Beside me, I heard Melissa shift. The sleeping bag rustled. More rustling, from her direction, from Trevor's direction. The sound of a zipper. Quiet, but unmistakable. Movement. The sleeping bags sliding against each other. Melissa's breathing changed, faster, shallower, a small sound, a gasp.

There was more movement. The sleeping bags shifting, fabric against fabric. Trevor's breathing, heavier now. I lay frozen, my eyes wide in the darkness, listening. Melissa made another sound. Quiet, trying to stay quiet, but I could hear it. Pleasure. The movements continued. Rhythmic. Careful. Her breathing became ragged. Small gasps in time with the movement. I knew what was happening. I could picture it even though I couldn't see. His hand. Her body. The darkness hiding everything but sound, a sharper gasp. Melissa's voice, barely a whisper.

The movement stopped. Breathing. Heavy breathing from both of them. Silence. Then the rustle of sleeping bags being rearranged, a zipper sliding closed. I lay there, my body tense, my heart hammering, staring into the dark. Melissa's breathing gradually slowed. Trevor's did the same. But I knew none of us were sleeping. I woke to gray light and the sound of the camp stove hissing. Trevor was already outside. Melissa lay beside me, still in her sleeping bag, eyes open.

"Morning," I said. She turned her head to look at me.

"Morning."

Her voice was soft, cautious. She sat up, pushed her hair back, and reached for her shoes without saying anything else. Outside, Trevor crouched by the stove, adjusting the flame under the kettle. He glanced up when we emerged.

"Coffee's almost ready," he said.

"Thanks," Melissa said. We stood around the picnic table, not quite looking at each other. Trevor poured water into the mugs, handed them out. I wrapped my hands around mine, focusing on the heat.

"Sleep okay?" Trevor asked.

"Fine," I said. Melissa nodded, sipping her coffee. Trevor pulled out the bagels again, the cream cheese. We ate standing in the same positions as yesterday, but the rhythm was off. Too much space between us. Too much

quiet. Trevor finished his bagel and set his mug on the table. Melissa picked it up and held it out to him.

"Here," she said. He reached for it. She stood on her toes and kissed him. Quick, light, her lips barely brushing his. She pulled back with a smile.

"Morning," she said. Trevor blinked, then smiled back.

"Morning."

Melissa looked at me.

"Still okay?"

My chest felt tight. I looked down at my coffee.

"Yeah."

She turned back to Trevor, her smile widening. We cleaned up breakfast, packed the food away. The morning stretched out, slow and uncertain. Trevor suggested we head to the river to wash dishes from last night.

We gathered the plates and utensils and walked down to the beach. Melissa knelt in the shallows, scrubbing a plate with a rag. Trevor crouched beside her, rinsing a pot in the current. I sat in one of the camping chairs we had dragged down, a book open in my lap.

I was not reading. Melissa said something to Trevor, too quiet for me to hear. He laughed. She moved closer, her shoulder against his.

Then she turned her head and kissed him. This one was longer. Her hand moved to his chest, fingers spreading over his shirt. His hand went to her waist, pulling her closer.

Their mouths moved together, no longer tentative. When they separated, both of them were breathing harder. Melissa's face was flushed, her eyes bright.

She glanced at me, checking if I was watching. I was. She smiled and turned back to the dishes like nothing had happened. They finished washing and carried the clean dishes back to camp. I followed, the book still in my hand, unread.

We ate lunch in relative silence. Sandwiches, chips, water from the cooler. When we finished, Melissa stood and stretched.

"Want to explore upriver?" she asked.

"Sure," Trevor said. I nodded. We set out along the bank. Trevor led, Melissa walked beside him. I trailed a few feet back. The river narrowed here, the current faster.

Trevor pointed at something in the water. Melissa leaned in to see. Her hand found his, their fingers interlacing. They walked hand in hand, talking

in low voices, at one point, the bank rose steep.

Trevor climbed up first. He reached back. Melissa took his hand. His other hand went to her hip, steadying her as she climbed. When she reached the top, she didn't let go of his hand. I climbed up on my own.

We kept walking. Melissa laughed at something Trevor said, the sound bright and free. She looked back over her shoulder at me and grinned, waving. Then she turned to Trevor, pulled him to a stop, and kissed him again.

This time she didn't pull back quickly. Her arms went around his neck. His hands moved to her waist, then lower, gripping her hips. They kissed like that for a long time, bodies pressed together. When they finally separated, Melissa looked back at me. Her cheeks were flushed, her eyes sparkling.

"You good?" she called. I nodded. She laughed, light and careless, and took Trevor's hand again. We reached a spot where the river widened into a pool. Trevor crouched at the edge, looking at something beneath the surface. Melissa knelt beside him, their heads close together.

"Trout," Trevor said, pointing.

"Where?"

"There. See the shadow?"

She leaned closer, her shoulder pressing against his.

"Oh yeah. I see it."

I stood back, hands in my pockets, after a while, Trevor stood.

"We should head back."

The walk back was quieter. Melissa and Trevor walked hand in hand, occasionally stopping to look at something, to kiss, to touch. Each time, Melissa would glance back at me, checking if I was watching. I was always watching.

When we reached camp, the clearing was bathed in late afternoon light. Trevor went to the cooler, pulled out beers, handed them around. We sat in the camping chairs, drinking. Melissa's chair was closer to Trevor's than it had been yesterday. She had one hand resting on the arm of his chair, her fingers drumming lightly.

"That was a good walk," she said.

"Yeah," Trevor agreed. She looked at me.

"You've been quiet."

"Just thinking."

"About what?"

"Nothing. Everything."

She studied my face, then smiled.

The sun dropped lower. The light went golden, then pink. The tent was dark when I climbed into my sleeping bag. Melissa was already inside, lying on her side facing the middle. Trevor was outside, his shadow moving across the canvas as he worked the fire. Melissa shifted closer to me. Her hand touched my arm.

"Are you okay?" she whispered. I didn't answer right away. "It's just for fun, you know that, right?" she said. "It doesn't mean anything."

"Okay."

"I mean it. This is just... exploration. Between all of us."

"Okay."

She was quiet for a moment. Then: "I think you liked watching."

It was not a question. I didn't deny it. Her hand moved from my arm to my face, turning me toward her. She leaned in and kissed me. Soft, brief, familiar.

"What if I want to keep going?" she whispered.

I swallowed. "Okay."

"You'll tell me if it's not okay?"

"Yeah."

She kissed me again, then settled back into her sleeping bag. The tent flap unzipped. Trevor climbed in, bringing the smell of smoke with him. He zipped the flap closed, clicked off the lantern, and slid into his sleeping bag. Darkness swallowed everything.

"Night," Trevor said quietly.

"Goodnight," Melissa murmured. I listened to them breathing. The tent was silent except for the river outside. Then I heard movement. Melissa shifting, her sleeping bag rustling. The sound of fabric sliding. She turned onto her other side, away from me. Toward Trevor.

The breathing pattern changed. It wasn't the steady rhythm of sleep. Broken, uneven, a whisper. Too quiet to make out the words. Melissa's voice. Trevor's response, equally quiet, a soft sound. Lips meeting, the wet slide of a kiss. I lay frozen, eyes open in the dark, staring at nothing.

The kissing continued, deeper now. I could hear it in the sounds, the small breaks for breath, the soft rustle of movement, a quiet laugh.

Melissa, trying to stay quiet, failing. More kissing, then silence, then Melissa shifted again. I heard the sleeping bag unzip.

There was slow, careful movement, the sound of bodies adjusting position. Trevor's sleeping bag unzipping too, fabric rustling, arms, legs, finding each other in the dark. Melissa made a sound, quiet, but unmistakable.

I held my breath. The movement became rhythmic, a gasp, short, high-pitched, inhaled fast, Melissa trying to stay silent.

There was silence again, then the movement resumed, the sleeping bags sliding against each other's bodies moving together, another gasp, quieter this time.

Melissa's breathing was ragged, trying to control it. I could picture it even though I couldn't see, his hands on her, her body responding, the darkness hiding everything but sound, the rhythm continued.

Melissa shifted. I heard fabric moving, the whisper of clothing being adjusted, a sharper intake of breath, the movement changed, more urgent now.

Melissa's breathing became faster. Small sounds escaping her throat despite her efforts to stay quiet, a whisper. Trevor's voice, too low to hear the words. Melissa's response was breathy and desperate.

The movement intensified. The sleeping bags shifted with the rhythm. Melissa gasped, louder this time, then caught herself. I heard her hand muffle her own mouth. The rhythm continued, relentless, her breathing grew frantic, small whimpers escaping through her fingers. Then a sharper sound, cut off almost immediately.

The movement stopped, heavy breathing, both of them trying to stay quiet and failing. There was a long silence, then the rustle of sleeping bags being rearranged, fabric sliding, zippers being opened or closed.

Melissa shifted back toward me, her breathing was still ragged, slowing gradually.

I felt her settle, facing me now, though I couldn't see her in the dark, her hand found mine between the sleeping bags. She squeezed once. I didn't squeeze back. She let go.

The tent fell silent except for breathing. It wasn't the steady rhythm of sleep. The broken, uneven pattern of people pretending. I lay there, my body tense, my heart hammering.

Beside me, Melissa's breathing gradually slowed. On her other side, Trevor's breathing evened out. But I knew none of us were sleeping. The darkness pressed in. The river made its constant sound outside.

I stared at nothing, replaying every sound in my mind, and didn't close my eyes. Morning came with light filtering through the canvas. I woke to movement. Melissa sitting up, stretching her arms overhead, arching her back.

She wore a thin tank top and underwear, having stripped down to sleep. She didn't reach for her clothes. She sat there, comfortable, her skin exposed to the morning air. Trevor was already outside. I heard the camp stove, the clatter of the coffee pot.

Melissa left her panties and tank top as they were, thin enough that I could see the outline of everything beneath. She ran her fingers through her hair, shaking it loose, and stepped out of the tent. I followed a minute later, pulling on a shirt.

She stood by the picnic table, talking to Trevor. Her posture was different. Shoulders back, chin up. When she laughed, she leaned into him, her hand resting on his forearm.

We ate breakfast standing. Coffee, bagels, the sun climbing higher. Melissa met Trevor's eyes when she spoke, held his gaze without looking away. She licked cream cheese from her thumb, slow, watching him watch her. When we finished, Trevor set his mug on the table. Melissa took his hand.

"Come here," she said. She pulled him to standing. He looked down at her, uncertain. She reached up, her hands going to his face, and kissed him. It wasn't tentative. It wasn't careful.

Her mouth opened against his, demanding. Her fingers threaded into his hair at the base of his skull, gripping. Trevor's hands went to her waist, pulling her closer. She pressed against him, her body molding to his.

The kiss deepened, her tongue against his, his hands sliding down to her hips, gripping harder. She made a sound into his mouth, hungry, desperate. Her hands moved from his hair to his shoulders, his chest, feeling the muscle beneath his shirt. His hands moved up her back, fingers splaying wide. She pulled back enough to breathe, her lips swollen, her eyes dark.

She kissed him again, harder this time, her hands twisted in his hair, pulling his head down to hers. His hands slid lower, cupping her ass, lifting her slightly.

She gasped against his mouth, her legs wrapping around his waist for a moment before she dropped back down. They broke apart, both breathing hard. Melissa turned her head and looked at me. Her face was flushed, her chest rising and falling rapidly. She smiled.

"Morning, Dave," she said. I didn't respond. She turned back to Trevor, her hands still on his chest.

"We should probably do something productive today."

"Probably," he said, his voice rough. She stepped back, her fingers trailing down his chest as she moved away.

"I'm going to wash up at the river."

She walked toward the beach, her hips swaying. Trevor watched her go, his hands hanging at his sides. I stood by the picnic table, my coffee mug cold in my hand. Trevor cleared his throat.

"I'll, uh, get started on breaking down some of this gear."

He moved to the tent, busying himself with organizing equipment. I stayed where I was, after a few minutes, Melissa came back from the river, her face and arms wet. She had tied her tank top up, exposing her stomach. Water droplets clung to her skin. She walked straight to Trevor. He was crouched by the gear, sorting through a duffel bag. She knelt beside him.

"What are you doing?" she asked.

"Just organizing."

She put her hand on his knee.

"Can it wait?"

He looked at her.

She leaned in and kissed him. Soft at first, then deeper. Her hand slid up his thigh. He dropped what he was holding and turned to her, his hands going to her waist. She shifted closer, pressing herself against him. They kissed like that, kneeling in the dirt, hands roaming, her fingers under his shirt, feeling his skin, his hands on her bare stomach, sliding up. She pulled back, breathing hard.

She kissed him again, cutting off whatever he was going to say. Her hands went to his hair, gripping, pulling. He groaned into her mouth. When they finally broke apart, she was straddling his lap, her arms around his neck. His hands were on her hips, holding her against him.

"We should probably stop," she said, not moving.

"Probably."

She kissed him once more, quick and hard, then climbed off his lap. She stood, adjusted her tank top, and walked back to the picnic table. Trevor stayed where he was, kneeling in the dirt, his breathing uneven. Melissa caught my eye.

"You want to go for a walk or something, Dave?"

"Not really."

"Trevor, want to show me that trail you mentioned? The one that goes to the lake?"

Trevor stood, brushing dirt from his knees.

"Yeah. Sure."

They walked to the trailhead together. Before they disappeared into the trees, Melissa looked back at me and waved. Then they were gone. I stood in the clearing alone, the morning sun bright and hot, and listened to their voices fade into the forest. They came back an hour later, walking close together, Trevor's arm around Melissa's waist. She was laughing at something he said, her face bright and flushed.

"We should swim," Melissa said.

"It's getting hot."

We changed into our swimsuits. When Melissa emerged from the tent, she wore the one-piece, no shorts over it this time.

The suit clung to her, outlining everything. Trevor had pulled a blanket from the tent and spread it on the stones near the water. He sat, leaning back on his hands. Melissa walked over and sat beside him.

I grabbed my chair and dragged it down to the beach, positioning it about ten feet away. I sat, the book open in my lap. Melissa looked at Trevor, then at me, then back at Trevor. She leaned in and kissed him.

Her hand went to his chest, fingers spreading over his skin. His hand moved to her waist, pulling her closer. The kiss deepened. She shifted, moving to straddle his lap, her knees on either side of his hips.

Her hands went to his hair, gripping. Trevor's hands moved over her back, down to her hips, pulling her tight against him. She rocked against him, her body moving in slow circles, a sound escaped her throat, low and hungry. His hands slid up her sides, thumbs brushing the sides of her breasts. She gasped into his mouth, her movements becoming more urgent. She broke the kiss, her breathing ragged.

Trevor's hands moved over her swimsuit, feeling her through the fabric. She arched into his touch, her head falling back.

Her hips moved against him, grinding. The sounds she made were raw, unfiltered. Trevor's mouth went to her neck, her collarbone. She clutched at his shoulders, her breathing coming in short gasps.

She turned her head and her eyes found mine. She held my gaze while she moved against Trevor, while his hands roamed over her body, while pleasure twisted her features. She didn't look away. Her mouth opened, a moan escaping. Still looking at me. Trevor's hand slid up, cupping her breast through the swimsuit. She gasped, her eyes closing for a moment, then opening again to find mine.

"Dave," she breathed. I gripped the arms of the chair, unable to move. Her hand moved between them, pressing against Trevor through his swim trunks. He groaned against her neck.

"I need more," she said. Trevor's hand went to the strap of her swimsuit, sliding it down her shoulder. She didn't stop him. The strap fell, exposing more skin. His mouth followed, kissing the newly bare skin. Melissa's head fell back, her eyes still on me.

His hand slid under the fabric of her swimsuit, disappearing beneath it, finding her breast. Melissa cried out, her body jerking, her hips grinding harder against him. I watched her face. The way pleasure moved across it. The way she bit her lip, trying to stay quiet, failing. Trevor's other hand moved lower, sliding down her stomach.

His hand disappeared under the bottom of her swimsuit. Melissa's whole body went rigid. Her eyes locked with mine, her mouth falling open.

Her hips started moving again, rocking against his hand. The sounds she made were desperate, pleading. Trevor's hand worked her, hidden beneath the fabric. I could see the movement, the rhythm. Melissa's breathing became frantic.

Her hand gripped Trevor's shoulder, nails digging in. Her other hand went to his wrist, holding his hand in place. She was close. I could see it in her face, in the tension of her body.

Her whole body shuddered. She came with a broken cry, her hips jerking, her hand pressing his harder against her. The orgasm tore through her while she stared at me, her eyes never leaving mine.

When it finally subsided, she collapsed forward onto Trevor's chest, trembling. His hand withdrew from her swimsuit. He wrapped his arms around her, holding her. She turned her head, her cheek against his chest,

and looked at me. She smiled, after a moment, she sat up. Her swimsuit was askew, one strap still down, her hair wild.

"I need to cool off," she said, her voice shaky. She stood and walked to the water on unsteady legs. She waded in to her waist, then dove under. Trevor stayed on the blanket, breathing hard, adjusting himself.

I sat in my chair, my whole body tense, my heart pounding. Melissa surfaced, pushing wet hair out of her face. She looked back at us, at me, and smiled again. Morning was thick and silent. We moved around each other with a new kind of tension. Breakfast was coffee and nothing else. No one was hungry. Melissa drained her mug and set it on the table.

"One more swim before we have to think about packing up."

Trevor nodded. I did the same. We changed in the tent, pulling on swimsuits. When we emerged, the sun was high and brutal. We walked to the river beach.

Trevor waded in first, diving under when the water reached his waist. Melissa followed, moving slower. Trevor surfaced and swam to her. His hands went to her waist, pulling her close. He kissed her, deep, urgent.

His hands slid down her sides, gripping her hips. She pressed against him, her arms wrapping around his neck. Her legs lifted, wrapping around his waist. He held her there, hands under her thighs, supporting her weight. The water rippled around them as they moved together, kissing, grinding against each other. Melissa's head fell back, her mouth open.

His mouth went to her neck, her shoulder. Her hips rocked against him, desperate. I sat on the shore, the book beside me, unopened. My eyes locked on them. They stayed like that, bodies intertwined, until Melissa finally pulled back.

"We should go back," she said, her voice rough. Trevor nodded, breathing hard. They walked out of the water together, dripping. Melissa's swimsuit clung to her, outlining everything. Trevor's arousal was visible through his trunks. We walked back to camp in silence. The clearing was blazing with midday heat. Melissa stopped at the edge of the campsite and turned to me. She smiled.

"It's all just for fun, right? Just to see what happens."

I didn't answer. She took Trevor's hand and led him to the tent. She unzipped the flap and pulled him inside. The flap stayed open. I could see inside. The light was diffused, golden, the canvas filtering the sun. Melissa and Trevor stood facing each other.

She reached for the straps of her swimsuit and slid them down her shoulders. She peeled the suit down her body, stepping out of it. She stood before him, naked. Trevor stared at her, frozen. She moved to him, her hands going to the waistband of his swim trunks. She hooked her fingers under the elastic and pulled them down. He stepped out of them. She took his hand and guided him down onto the sleeping bag.

"Lie back."

He did. She positioned herself over him, her knees on either side of his chest. She moved up higher until she was positioned over his face. She looked back at me through the open tent flap. Our eyes met.

"Just for fun," she said again. "Okay?"

I couldn't speak. She lowered herself onto Trevor's mouth. Her whole body jerked, a gasp tearing from her throat. Her hands went to his hair, gripping. Trevor's hands moved to her hips, holding her in place. She started moving, rocking against his face. The sounds she made were raw, desperate.

Her head fell back, her eyes closing. Then they opened again, finding mine. She held my gaze while she rode Trevor's face, while pleasure twisted her features, while her body chased release.

Her movements became more frantic, more desperate. Trevor's hands gripped her tighter, holding her against him.

Her whole body went rigid. She came with a sharp cry, her hips jerking, her hands fisting in Trevor's hair. The orgasm seemed to go on forever. When it finally subsided, she collapsed forward, bracing her hands on the sleeping bag above Trevor's head, trembling. She looked back at me, her face flushed, her chest heaving.

She shifted, moving down Trevor's body. Her hand wrapped around him, stroking.

She lowered her mouth to him. I sat outside the tent, watching through the open flap, watching everything, unable to move. Melissa's head moved up and down, her mouth working him. Trevor groaned, his hips lifting slightly off the sleeping bag. She pulled back, releasing him with a wet sound. She looked at him, her eyes dark.

She shifted, positioning herself back over his face. But this time she faced me, looking directly at me through the open tent flap as she lowered herself onto his mouth. Her eyes locked with mine as Trevor's tongue found her.

Her hands went to his hair, gripping, pulling. She started moving, grinding against his face.

Trevor's hands moved to her hips, trying to control the pace, but she pulled his head harder against her.

Her breathing became ragged. The sounds she made were raw, unfiltered. It wasn't thing held back. I watched her face. The way her mouth fell open. The way her eyes squeezed shut, then opened again to find mine. The way pleasure twisted her features.

Trevor's hands gripped her harder, holding her in place while his tongue worked her. The wet sounds filled the tent, obscene and impossible to ignore. Melissa's whole body started trembling.

Her hips rocked faster, chasing something. Her hands twisted in his hair, holding him exactly where she needed him.

I could see every muscle in her body drawing tight. The way her thighs shook on either side of Trevor's head. The way her stomach muscles clenched. Her breathing turned into gasps, short and desperate.

Her whole body went rigid. For a moment, she was completely still, suspended on the edge. Then she shattered.

Her body convulsed, violent tremors moving through her. Her hips jerked against Trevor's mouth, beyond her control. The orgasm tore through her in waves. I watched each one hit. The way her back arched. The way her thighs clamped around Trevor's head. The way her hands pulled at his hair. She was shaking so hard she could barely stay upright. Her voice broke into incoherent sounds, gasps and cries and Trevor's name.

But he didn't stop. His hands held her hips in place, his mouth relentless, another wave hit her. She screamed, her whole body jerking.

The tremors continued, rolling through her. Her upper body collapsed forward, bracing on the sleeping bag, but her hips stayed locked against Trevor's face. Finally, the waves began to subside. She was gasping for air, her whole body still shaking with aftershocks.

Trevor released her. She collapsed to the side, curling into herself, trembling. She lay there, her chest heaving, her skin flushed and damp with sweat. Small tremors still moved through her body, after a long moment, she opened her eyes and looked at me. Her face was soft, dazed, transformed.

She rolled onto her back, still trying to catch her breath. Trevor lay beside her, his face wet, his breathing heavy. Melissa turned her head to

look at him.

She reached over and wrapped her hand around him, stroking slowly.

Trevor groaned.

She positioned herself on her hands and knees, looking back at him over her shoulder.

Trevor moved behind her, his hands going to her hips. She looked at me through the open tent flap.

I sat frozen, unable to look away. Trevor positioned himself at her entrance. Melissa's eyes stayed locked with mine.

Trevor pushed forward. Melissa's mouth fell open, a cry tearing from her throat. Her arms shook, struggling to hold herself up.

Trevor started moving, slow at first, then faster. The sound of their bodies meeting filled the tent. Melissa's head dropped, her hair falling forward.

Trevor's grip on her hips tightened. His thrusts became more forceful. Melissa's arms gave out. Her face pressed into the sleeping bag, her back arching more, changing the angle.

Her voice was muffled against the fabric, but I could hear every word, every sound. Trevor drove into her, relentless. Melissa's whole body shook with each thrust.

Her hand reached back, finding Trevor's thigh, pulling him deeper.

Her body went rigid again. Her voice broke with a scream. Trevor thrust deep and held himself there, his own release taking him.

They stayed locked together, both trembling, both crying out. When it finally subsided, Trevor pulled out and collapsed beside her.

Melissa lay face down on the sleeping bag, her whole body shaking with aftershocks. Neither of them moved. I sat outside the tent, my heart pounding, my whole body tense, and watched them breathe. They lay there, both breathing hard. Melissa's body still trembled with small aftershocks. Trevor's hand rested on her back, stroking gently.

After a long moment, Melissa pushed herself up onto her hands and knees. She crawled down Trevor's body. She looked at me through the open tent flap, making sure I was watching. Then she lowered her mouth to him. Trevor groaned, his head falling back.

His hands went to her hair, gentle at first, then gripping tighter. Melissa took him deep, her head bobbing in a steady rhythm. I could see her cheeks

hollow as she sucked, could hear the wet sounds, could see Trevor's hips lifting slightly off the sleeping bag.

She pulled back, letting him slip from her mouth. She stroked him with her hand while she looked at me.

She smiled and lowered her mouth to him again. This time she took him deeper, her throat working around him. Trevor's hands formed fists in her hair.

"Fuck. That feels good."

She worked him like that for several minutes, her hand and mouth moving in tandem. Trevor's breathing became ragged, his hips moving in time with her rhythm. Then she pulled off him completely.

She turned around, positioning herself over his face, her knees on either side of his head, her hands braced on his thighs. From where I sat, I could see everything, her lowering herself onto his mouth, her back arching as his tongue found her, her mouth opening to take him in again.

They moved together, both giving and receiving pleasure. The sounds filled the tent, wet, obscene, desperate. Melissa moaned around him, the vibrations making Trevor groan beneath her. His hands gripped her hips, holding her against his face while his tongue worked her.

She took him deeper, her head moving faster. Her hips rocked against his mouth, seeking more friction. I watched her body respond, the way her thighs trembled on either side of his head, the way her back arched when he hit a particularly sensitive spot, the way her movements became less coordinated as pleasure overtook her. She pulled off him, gasping.

But she lowered her mouth to him again, determined. Trevor's hips thrust up, pushing deeper into her mouth. She took it, relaxing her throat. His hands pulled her harder against his face. She cried out around him, the sound muffled. Both of them were close.

I could see it in the tension of their bodies, hear it in the desperation of their sounds. Melissa's movements became frantic, her mouth working him faster, her hips grinding against his face without rhythm. Trevor's hips jerked, his grip on her hips bruising. His tongue worked her relentlessly.

Melissa's whole body went rigid, a muffled scream escaping around him. Her hips jerked against his face, riding out the waves. The sounds she made pushed Trevor over the edge. He thrust up into her mouth one final time and came. Melissa took it all, swallowing, her body still shaking with

her own release. When they finally went still, she lifted herself off his face and turned around. She collapsed beside him, both of them breathing hard.

They lay there for a moment. Then Melissa sat up, looking down at Trevor.

Her hand wrapped around him, stroking gently. He was still semi-hard, sensitive from finishing.

She stroked him. Slowly, he started to harden again in her hand.

She leaned down and took him in her mouth again, working him with her tongue until he was fully hard. Then she released him and straddled his hips. She looked at me through the tent opening.

She positioned herself above him, her hand guiding him to her entrance.

She started to lower herself onto him. Her mouth fell open as she took him in, inch by inch. Her eyes stayed locked on mine.

She sank down completely, taking all of him inside her. She sat there for a moment, adjusting, her chest heaving. Trevor's hands moved to her hips. Melissa started to move. She rose up on her knees, lifting herself almost completely off Trevor, then sank back down. She did it again. Rising up, pausing at the tip, then lowering herself. Trevor's hands gripped her hips, trying to pull her down faster, but she resisted.

She repeated the motion, up, pause, down. Each time slower than the last. Trevor groaned beneath her.

She rose up again, this time stopping with the tip inside her. She held herself there, trembling with the effort. Her face changed. Uncertainty flickered across it. She twisted around to look at me through the open tent flap. Our eyes met. She bit her lip, hesitating. I stared back at her, frozen. She searched my face for something. permission protest, anything.

She turned back to Trevor. Her expression hardened with resolve. Staring into my eyes over her shoulder, she dropped down, taking all of him in one fast motion. Her mouth fell open, a cry tearing from her throat.

Her whole body shuddered. She stayed there, impaled on him, trembling.

She started moving. Rising and falling, her pace quickening. Each time she dropped down, she cried out. Trevor's hands moved from her hips to her breasts, cupping them, thumbs brushing her nipples.

Her movements became faster, more desperate. The sounds of their bodies meeting filled the tent, rhythmic and obscene.

Her voice climbed higher. Her control was slipping. Trevor thrust up to meet her. She screamed.

The rhythm built. Both of them moving together now. Harder, faster. Melissa's head fell back, her mouth open.

Her body seized. She came with a sharp cry, her hips jerking, her hands bracing on Trevor's chest. But she didn't stop moving. She rode through it, chasing.

Trevor rolled them, putting Melissa on her back. He drove into her hard. She wrapped her legs around him, pulling him deeper.

He pounded into her. The sleeping bag bunched beneath them. Melissa's hands clawed at his back.

She scrambled onto her hands and knees. He moved behind her and thrust back in. The new angle made her scream.

He gripped her hips and drove into her. Relentless. Punishing. Melissa's arms gave out. Her face pressed into the sleeping bag, her back arching.

Her whole body shook with each thrust. The sounds she made were animal, raw.

She shattered, her body convulsing. But Trevor didn't slow. He pulled her up, her back against his chest. One hand on her breast, the other between her legs.

Her head fell back against his shoulder. Trevor laid her on her side, lifting her leg, and entered her from behind. The new angle made both of them groan. He moved in long, deep strokes. Melissa reached back, her hand in his hair, pulling him down to kiss her. They moved together, bodies slick with sweat, completely lost in each other.

Trevor said. He rolled her onto her back again. She wrapped her legs around him as he pushed back inside. Their eyes locked. He moved slowly now, deeply, each thrust harder.

Melissa breathed. Trevor's rhythm increased. Melissa's hands moved to his face, holding him. His thrusts became erratic. He was close. Trevor pulled out, kneeling over her. She sat up, her hand wrapping around him, stroking.

Her hand moved faster. Trevor groaned, his body tensing. He came with a guttural moan. Hot ropes of cum landed on her chest, her neck, her face. Melissa gasped, her mouth opening, her tongue darting out to catch some on her lips. More landed on her cheek, her chin. She laughed, breathless and wild.

She kept stroking him, milking every last drop. It covered her chest, dripped down her neck, a streak across her face glistened in the sunlight. She licked at what had landed on her lips, her eyes closing.

Trevor collapsed beside her, chest heaving. Melissa lay back, covered in him, and smiled. Then she turned her head to look at me through the open tent flap.

"Just playing around, right?" She ran her finger through the cum on her chest and brought it to her mouth, her eyes on me the whole time, and then she laughed and rolled away.

The tent was silent except for breathing. Three sets of lungs working to pull air, to slow racing hearts. Melissa lay on her back, her chest rising and falling. Cum still glistened on her skin, drying in the afternoon heat.

Trevor lay beside her, one arm thrown over his eyes. I sat outside the tent, frozen in my chair, my whole body rigid. Minutes passed. The breathing slowed. Melissa sat up, reaching for her swimsuit.

She pulled it on without cleaning herself off first, the fabric sticking to her damp skin. Trevor found his swim trunks and pulled them on. They didn't look at each other. Melissa crawled out of the tent. She stood, brushing dirt from her knees, and walked past me toward the river without a word. I watched her wade into the water and duck under, washing herself clean. Trevor emerged from the tent, his face unreadable.

"We should probably start packing."

I nodded. We took down the tent in silence, folded the sleeping bags. Loaded the gear into the SUV. The routine was mechanical, familiar. No one spoke beyond the necessities. Hand me that. Where does this go. Melissa came back from the river, her hair wet, her swimsuit clinging to her. She helped pack without meeting anyone's eyes. When everything was loaded, we stood in the clearing for a moment. The fire ring sat cold and empty. The spot where the tent had been showed flattened grass, already springing back.

Trevor walked to the driver's side. Melissa climbed into the passenger seat. I got in the back, surrounded by gear. The SUV started. We pulled out onto the dirt road. The drive was long. Trevor kept the windows down. No music this time. Just wind and road noise. Melissa stared out her window, her hand trailing in the air.

I watched the trees blur past. The dirt road became gravel, then pavement. The forest thinned, farmland, then suburbs, then the city. No one

spoke. When we hit traffic, Trevor drummed his fingers on the wheel. Melissa checked her phone, scrolling through messages she had missed. Normal life creeping back in. Trevor pulled up in front of Melissa's apartment building. He put the SUV in park.

"Thanks for coming," he said, his voice flat.

"Yeah. Thanks for having us," Melissa said. I grabbed my bag from the back. Melissa got hers. We stood on the sidewalk. Trevor looked at us through the open window.

"See you around."

"Yeah. See you," Melissa said. He drove away without another word. We climbed the stairs to Melissa's apartment. She unlocked the door and we stepped inside. The space felt small, stale. Everything exactly as we had left it. We dropped our bags by the door. Melissa unzipped hers and started pulling out dirty clothes.

"I'm going to start laundry."

"Okay."

She carried the clothes to the small washer in her bathroom. I followed with my own dirty things. We sorted in silence. Lights, darks. She measured detergent, poured it in.

"Do you work tomorrow?" she asked.

"Yeah. Night shift."

"I'm on early. Four AM start."

"That's rough."

"It's fine. I'm used to it."

She closed the washer lid.

"Do you want something to eat? I could order Vietnamese."

"Sure."

She pulled out her phone and placed an order from our usual place. The same thing we always got. While we waited, she put things away. Her toiletries back in the bathroom. Her book on the nightstand. Restoring order. I sat on the couch, my phone in my hand, not looking at anything. The food arrived. We ate at her small table, the TV on in the background. Some show we had seen before. Comfortable, familiar.

"This episode is good," she said.

"Yeah."

"Remember when we first watched it? You fell asleep."

"I was tired."

She smiled.

"Baby, you're always tired."

We finished eating. She threw away the containers, wiped down the table. I brought the laundry basket to her.

"Washer's done."

"Thanks."

She moved the clothes to the dryer, started it. I stood in the bathroom doorway, watching her work. She glanced at me from the corner of her eye, a small smile played at her lips. She turned to face me, leaning against the dryer.

"Camping was fun."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah." Her smile widened, becoming something else. Knowing. Satisfied.

"We should go again really soon."

She held my gaze for a moment, then turned back to the dryer, adjusting the settings. I stood there, watching her move through her apartment.

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